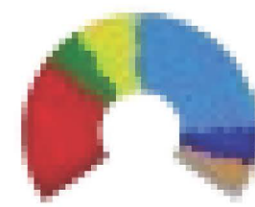




State Commission
for Persons with
Disabilities



POLITICS &
DISABILITY
FORUM

HANDBOOK ON ATTITUDINAL BARRIER AND USAGE OF DISABILITY SENSITIVE LANGUAGE



FEBRUARY 2024

VISION OF THE HANDBOOK

This document envisions a world where attitudinal barriers towards disability fade away, replaced by inclusive language and genuine understanding. We believe that the words we choose have the power to empower and uplift, or isolate and exclude. Here, we delve into the nuances of disability-sensitive language, exploring its impact on individuals, communities, and broader societal perceptions. Ultimately, we strive to facilitate meaningful conversations, dismantling prejudice and paving the way for a respectful and inclusive future for all.

Special Thanks to:

Dr. Pramod Sawant (Hon'ble Chief Minister of Goa)

Shri. Subhash Phal Dessai (Hon'ble Minister of Social Welfare, Goa)

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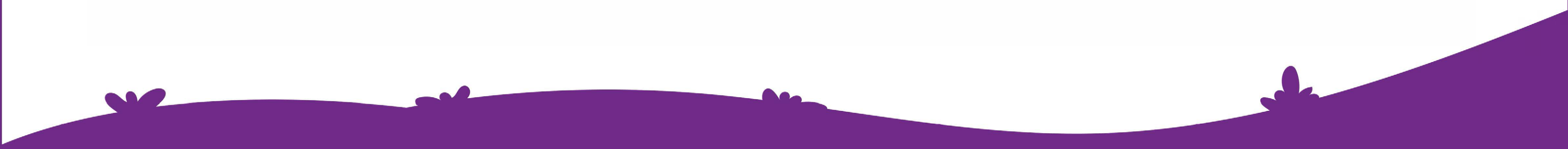


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BACKGROUND NOTE

The Government of Goa started one of its kind event Purple Fest for the disability community. The first edition of the Purple Fest, India's first-of its kind inclusive fest, a distinctive 3-day event was held from 6th to 8th January 2023 at the Entertainment Society of Goa. Purple Fest was organised by the Office of the State Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities, Govt of Goa, in association with the Directorate of Social Welfare-Goa, Entertainment Society of Goa and Department of Tourism. The Hon'ble Prime Minister, Shri Narendra Modi, applauded the efforts of the Goa State in one of his "Mann ki Baat" episodes.



"My dear countrymen, what comes to your mind when someone talks about the tourist hub Goa? Naturally, as soon as the name of Goa is referred to; first of all, the beautiful coastline, beaches and favorite food items come to mind. But something happened in Goa this month, which is in the headlines. Today in "Mann ki baat" I want to share this with all of you - This event happened in Goa - Purple Fest. How big an occasion Purple Fest was, you can all guess from the fact that more than 50,000 brothers and sisters of ours participated in it. The people who came here were thrilled about the fact that they could now enjoy Miramar beach to the fullest. In fact, Miramar beach has become one of the accessible beaches of Goa for our divyang brothers and sisters ... For making Purple Fest a success, I congratulate all the people who participated in it. Along with this, I also congratulate those volunteers, who came together to work day and night to organise this. I have full faith that such campaigns will prove to be very effective in realising our vision of accessible India."



Our country has taken several strides towards inclusiveness of PwDs across domains. Under the aegis of "Sabka Saath. Sabha Vikas, Sabka Vishwas, Sabka Prayas". Our leadership has given a slogan of inclusiveness that involves participation by every community and also ensures dignity to them.

The disability sector in India is experiencing a notable transformation as different ministries are taking initiatives to ensure social spaces are accessible to people with disabilities. As an example, in 2023, the Ministry of Sports, the Ministry of Culture, the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology, and others released their respective guidelines under the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Rules, 2017. Consequently, it is imperative that inclusivity transcends the mere textual confines of laws and policies, and that society embraces individuals with disabilities. The embodiment of fraternity in the Preamble of our constitution can only be realized through the active engagement of society. Moreover, the functional implementation of the accessible norms established by the government apparatus is contingent upon the participation of other stakeholders.

Objective of the booklet

The primary objective of this booklet is to draw attention to the often-neglected aspect of attitudinal barriers and the significant role that language usage plays in reinforcing such barriers. Effective communication is crucial to inclusiveness, and the absence of empathy and inclusive tone can further endanger the community's interests. Persons with Disabilities (PwDs) have traditionally been viewed from a sympathetic perspective, perpetuating the institutionalisation of the charity model in both formal and informal communications. This publication endeavours to deconstruct several of these biases and provide a set of guiding principles that can reference our communication, particularly for media.

The portrayal of stories by media on the topic of disability seems to be influenced by social norms. Hence, they often end up succumbing to stereotypes when reporting on disability or about PwDs. It is, therefore, expected that media stakeholders will peruse this compilation for a more nuanced understanding of the subject of disability.

Purple Fest

The Purple Fest offers a variety of recreational activities that showcase a unique perspective apart from everyday life. It is aimed at creating an inclusive environment where PwD can also participate in these activities, given that they have access to an accessible space. The events includes sports, beach tours, musical performances, and more. Purple Fest garnered significant attention for its potential to catalyze a transformative shift in disability rights and inclusion, akin to the impact of Camp

Jened in the 1970s. As India's first-of-its-kind inclusive festival, Purple Fest fosters a barrier-free environment where individuals with disabilities orchestrate and partake in diverse cultural, academic, and sporting events. This creates an alternative space that transcends the limitations of mainstream activities. The festival's ethos mirrors the utopian vision of Camp Jened, which championed social integration and empowerment for individuals with disabilities. However, Purple Fest expands upon this vision by actively promoting principles of non-discrimination and fostering a vibrant community where new ideas and perspectives can flourish.

Although there are many challenges ahead for us, including ensuring longterm sustainability, expanding participation, and effectively translating the festival's spirit into tangible social change, we remain optimistic about the potential of the Purple Fest to serve as a catalyst for a more inclusive and equitable society in India. Its unique blend of celebration, community building, and relentless pursuit of inclusion has the potential to replicate the transformative impact of Camp Jened for a new generation. However, concerted efforts and sustained collaboration are paramount to ensure that the promise of Purple Fest translates into enduring positive change. We are striving towards it.

“Overlooking or ignoring the plight of disabled people is not an option that an acceptable theory of Justice can have.”

- Amartya Sen, Idea of Justice

EVOLUTION OF DISABILITY MOVEMENT IN INDIA

Historically, Indian society has accepted the diverseness of the people. The story of Ashtavakra, who attained the status of Brahmrishi (the highest position of sage), is narrated in our Puranas and Ramayana. Society admonished him throughout his life, but he attained a high status in the court of King Janaka (Father of Sita). He also wrote Ashtavakra Samhita passing on his knowledge and wisdom. Similarly, in Mahabharata, King Dhritrashtra was the central figure who lived with Blindness. He was known to possess otherworldly strength and was believed to be able to fight 100 elephants at a time. In our cultural history as well, Kalidasa, who is considered to be one of the greatest poets and playwrights in the Sanskrit language, is believed to live with an intellectual disability.^[i]

Thus, our ancient history comprises innumerable characters living with disability who played significant roles in shaping today's world. India is not secluded from the concept of disability but has historically been at the forefront of their inclusion. Our epics and history portray a picture of empowerment, inclusivity, dignity, and opportunity. The characters are identified beyond their disability. Hence, there has been substantial emphasis on the social interaction of individuals with disabilities and how society perceives these traits.

The laws related to persons with disabilities weren't consolidated but were present in other legislations like the Indian Penal Code of 1660, the Indian Evidence Act of 1672, legislation governing property, inheritance and transfer, and family law.

The Indian Lunacy Act, 1912 was enacted by the colonial government to consolidate all provisions related to lunatics and provide for their management. The act defined lunatics as "an idiot or a person of unsound mind".^[ii] The legislation perpetuated a structural bias against disabled people as any person could be termed as a person of unsound mind. This legislation was only replaced after

65 years with the Mental Health Act, 1987. The statement of object and reasons for the act states that with the rapid advance of medical science and the understanding of the nature of the malady, it has become necessary to have fresh legislation with provisions for the treatment of mentally ill persons in accordance with the new approach.

After the establishment of the United Nations, certain overarching instruments for upholding the rights of human beings were adopted. These documents also covered PwD within their ambit. For instance, the United Nations Declaration of Human Rights was adopted in 1946, which applied to all people without any distinction, including those with disabilities. It emphasizes fundamental rights like equality, non-discrimination, and the right to life, liberty, and security of person.

The decade of the 60s and 70s was a significant time for the human rights movement across the globe. America was witnessing a civil rights movement demanding equality for people of color. Similarly, a new wave of feminist movement also spread worldwide, demanding gender equality. In this new wave of human rights-centric advocacy, the marginalization of PwD was also witnessed. A small group within this large movement also started demanding equality and non-discrimination for PwDs.^[iii]

In 1976, the United Nations General Assembly passed a resolution to declare 1961 to be the Internal Year of Disabled Persons.^[iv] The United Nations announced 1963-1992 as the United Nations Decade of Disabled Persons. This proclamation by the UN was intended to prompt an increase in activity designed to improve the situation and status of persons with disabilities. Emphasis was placed on raising new financial resources and improving education and employment opportunities for persons with disabilities.^[v] As a result, the Indian gov-



ernment set up the Rehabilitation Council of India in 1966 as a society. Later, it enacted The Rehabilitation Council of India Act 1992 to make it a statutory body.

In 1993, the UN also adopted 'The Standard Rules on the Equalization of Opportunities for Persons with Disabilities', which provided practical guidelines for governments to implement policies and programs that promote the inclusion and participation of disabled people. Subsequently, the Parliament of India also enacted the National Trust for the Welfare of Persons with Autism, Cerebral Palsy, Mental Retardation and Multiple Disabilities Act, 1999. The stated object of the legislation was to provide for the constitution of a body at the National level for the Welfare of Persons with Autism, Cerebral Palsy, Mental Retardation and Multiple Disabilities and for matter connected therewith or incidental thereto.

In 1993, the United Nations Economic and Social Commission for Asia and the Pacific (UNESCAP) declared the 90s as the 'Asian-Pacific Decade of Disabled Persons' with the Proclamation on the Full Participation and Equality of People with Disabilities. Few years later, the first disability-centric legislation was enacted by India in 1995, the Persons with Disability (Equal Opportunities, Protection of Rights and Full Participation) Act, 1995 (PDA). This law defined 7 types of disabilities- blindness, low vision, leprosy cured, hearing impairment, locomotor disability, mental retardation, and mental illness. One of the significant developments through this act was the reservation of 3% for PwDs in government jobs. Although the PDA was a watershed moment in disability inclusion, it failed to eradicate the systematic discrimination against or ensure accessibility of spaces for them. The PDA was also limited to PwD with more than 40% disability. Hence, a large section of the population felt out of the protection granted under the PDA.[\[vi\]](#)

The National Council for Handicapped Welfare was established in 2004 to develop policy guidelines for the country and prioritize disability programs. This council consisted of rehabilitation experts and central and state ministers and was responsible for overseeing the activities of the central and state governments as well as the voluntary sector.

In 2006, the central government developed the first National Policy for PwD. This was the first national policy document formulated for PwD and served as

as a vision document for the policies and laws. The policy was directed at the Physical, Education, and Economic Rehabilitation of PwDs. In addition, the policy also focuses on rehabilitating women and children with disabilities, a barrier-free environment, social security, research, etc.[vii]

The watershed movement in the disability movement came with the adoption of the UN Convention on Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD). India was one of the first countries to ratify UNCRPD on 1st October 2007. This was a significant step forward for the country in its commitment to promoting the rights and well-being of its disabled citizens. The ratification also started formulating a more nuanced and comprehensive bill that abides by the principles of UNCRPD- non-discrimination and reasonable accommodation.

After multiple rounds of draft, consultation, and feedback, the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 (RPwD Act) was passed in December 2016 and became operative on 1st April 2017. This marked a significant departure in the understanding of disability from a medical model to a societal model. The RPwD Act defined a person with a disability as “means a person with long-term physical, mental, intellectual or sensory impairment which, in interaction with barriers, hinders his full and effective participation in society equally with others”.[viii] The RPwD also expanded the definition of “barrier” and included “... any factor including communicational, cultural, economic, environmental, institutional, political, social, attitudinal or structural factors which hampers the full and effective participation of persons with disabilities in society”.[ix]

Meanwhile, the central government also devised an umbrella scheme called “Sugamya Bharat” (Accessible India Campaign). This revolutionary program aims to give people with disabilities equal opportunities to participate in all aspects of life and live independently. The campaign focuses on developing accessible physical environments, transportation systems, and information and communication ecosystems. In 2022, the Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment developed a new draft National Policy for Persons with Disabilities. The principle of the draft policy is to showcase the Government’s commitment to the inclusion and empowerment of persons with disabilities by providing a mechanism that ensures their full participation in society. The policy document incorporates all the developments made in the disability movement in India since the

last national policy of 2006. The policy document is in the discussion stage and is hoped to be implemented soon.[\[x\]](#)

Over the past decade, the disability rights movement in India has grown and evolved from a mere umbrella scheme for PwDs to a robust legislation and, now, a bold and groundbreaking National Policy for PwDs. This remarkable journey only highlights the government's unwavering commitment to the integration of PwDs in our nation's mainstream affairs and eliminating the deep-seated prejudices and stereotypes that have long held them back.

ATTITUDINAL BARRIER AGAINST PERSONS WITH DISABILITIES

Attitudinal barriers are frequently disregarded while identifying impediments in the disability sector. The attitude of society can have an impact on other barriers, including infrastructure, economic, or environmental barriers. Disability is often associated with its physical or visible aspects, and as a result, other aspects, such as attitudinal barriers, are frequently disregarded or downplayed.

Understanding attitudinal barrier

Attitudinal barriers encompass adverse perceptions, preconceived biases, and discriminatory attitudes harbored by individuals and society toward Persons with Disabilities. These barriers transcend physical impediments and instead manifest as cognitive, emotional, and social hurdles that curtail opportunities, access, and equality for PwDs.[xi] The inconspicuous nature of these obstacles renders them difficult to detect and eliminate. These impediments are not singular but rather multifaceted, functioning on various levels. For instance, a woman with a disability may face discrimination in her workplace owing to her identity as a woman and a person with a disability. Therefore, determining the root cause of her discrimination can prove to be a challenging task.[xii]

Paternalistic views treating PwDs as incapable, fear and misunderstanding fueling exclusion, and deeply ingrained stereotypes limiting their potential — these are the invisible walls woven from attitudinal barriers. The consequences are far-reaching, affecting not just access to spaces and resources but also self-esteem, mental health, and overall quality of life.[xiii]

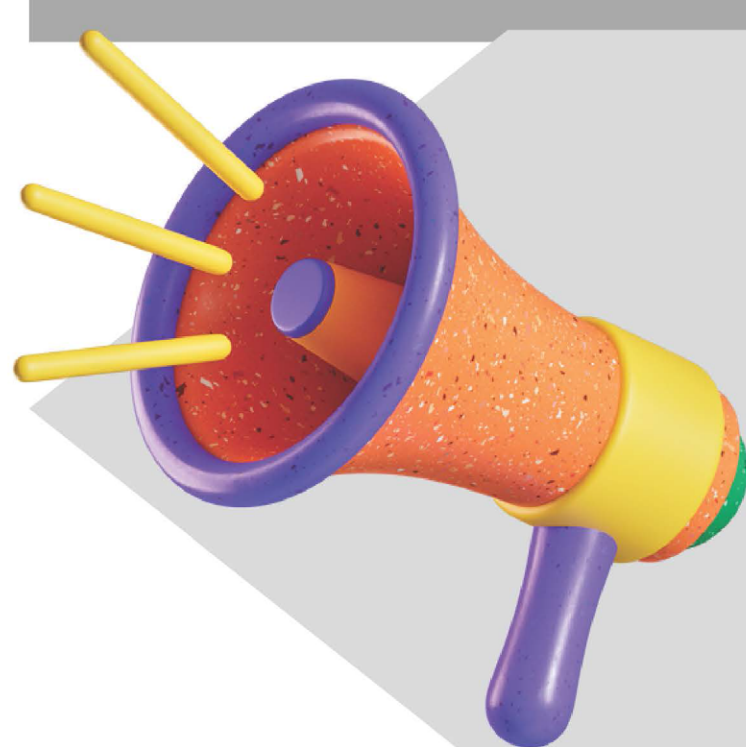
Reasonable accommodation to overcome attitudinal barrier

UNCRPD underlines the principle of non-discrimination against persons with disabilities. This concept is imbibed in the idea of reasonable accommodation. Hence, any person denying a person with disabilities a reasonable accommodation will be dis-

criminating against them. Section 2(h) of the RPwD Act also defines discrimination as “in relation to disability, means any distinction, exclusion, or restriction based on disability which is the purpose or effect of impairing or nullifying the recognition, enjoyment or exercise on an equal basis with others of all human rights and fundamental freedoms in the political, economic, social, cultural, civil or any other field and includes all forms of discrimination and denial of reasonable accommodation”.

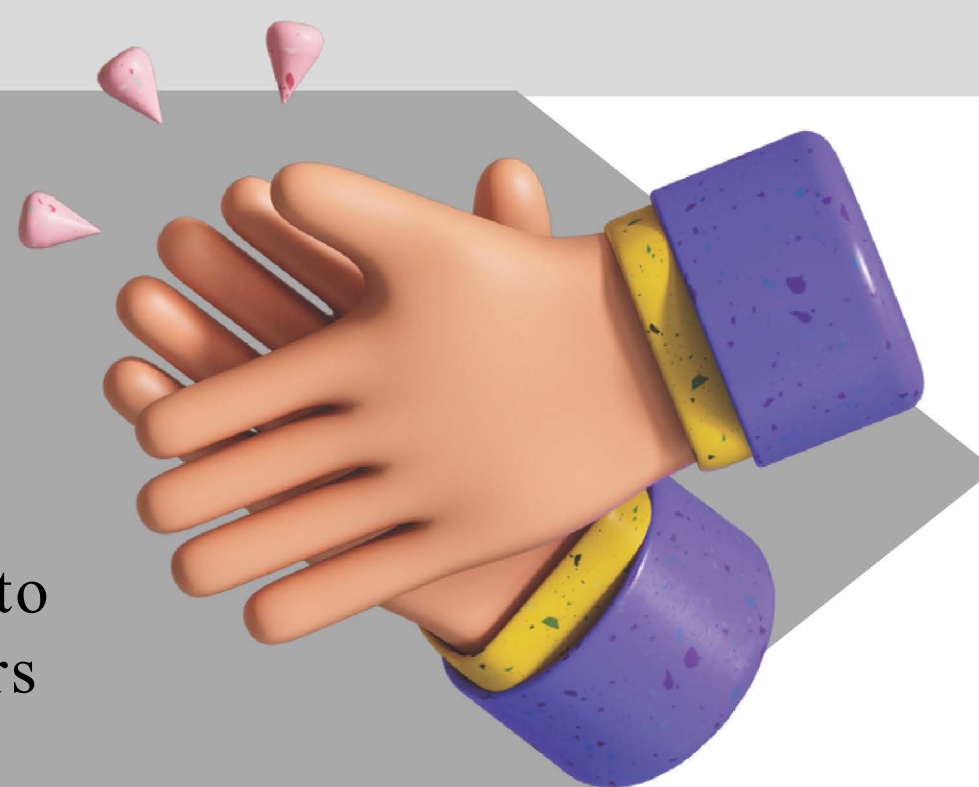
It should be noted that reasonable accommodation for persons with disabilities encompasses not just physical accessibility but also the creation of an environment that upholds all fundamental rights of individuals with disabilities.[xiv] If, for instance, an employee with a disability is granted accessible office space but is subjected to verbal ridicule due to their disability or is denied work opportunities as a result of disability-based stereotypes, such actions would constitute a failure to provide reasonable accommodation.[xv]

STEP 1: Promoting positive media representation of PwDs: Showcase their diverse talents, skills, and contributions, challenging negative stereotypes and highlighting their capabilities.



STEP 2: Providing platforms for PwDs to share their stories and experiences: This can foster empathy and understanding by allowing others to gain insight into their perspectives.

STEP 3: Supporting community-led initiatives by and for PwDs: Empower them to advocate for their own needs and lead efforts to dismantle attitudinal barriers



Reasonable accommodations are commonly perceived to mitigate physical and communication barriers that manifest in tangible forms.^[xvi] Despite being challenging, a comprehensive four-pronged strategy can be implemented to introduce reasonable accommodations in the institutional framework.

The government has undertaken significant measures to address attitudinal barriers through the implementation of a designated sensitization scheme under the Scheme for Implementation of Persons with Disabilities Act (SIPDA), which is an extension of the umbrella scheme of Sugamya Bharat. The government also celebrates the achievement of PwD through national awards in different categories that underlines their achievement across sectors. Nevertheless, the government's efforts' success is contingent upon all stakeholders' active involvement.

WHY LANGUAGE MATTERS WHEN TALKING DISABILITY

Language is dynamic and nuanced, changing at a rapid pace along with social norms, perceptions, and opportunities for inclusion. Using the correct language when discussing disability is not just about being polite. It's also about being fair and accurate. Using language that puts the person first, like "person who is blind" instead of "blind person," is crucial because it shows that the person is more than just their disability.^[xvii] It also helps to stop harmful stereotypes. Using neutral and descriptive language is also important. Instead of saying "confined to a wheelchair," we can say "uses a wheelchair." This kind of language helps us to understand and respect the experiences of people with disabilities. It also helps to stop negative attitudes and assumptions. By using careful and thoughtful language, we can help to create a more equal and fair society. We can help to build better relationships with people who have disabilities. And we can challenge unfair attitudes and beliefs.

Breaking the social stigmas

The social model of disability challenges the traditional medical perspective, which views disability as solely a problem residing within the individual's body. Instead, it proposes that disability is primarily created by societal barriers and discriminatory attitudes that limit the opportunities and participation of individuals with impairments.^[xviii]

Under this model, the focus shifts from "fixing" the individual to dismantling the environmental and social obstacles that hinder their full inclusion. Recognizing disability as a product of social structures empowers individuals and advocates to demand societal change, pushing for inclusive design, anti-discrimination legislation, and broader cultural shifts that prioritize accessibility and equal opportunities for all.^[xix]

DO

- Ask persons with disabilities directly what their accessibility preferences are.
- Treat all adults as adults.
- Speak directly to the person, not to their sign interpreter, personal assistant, etc.
- Ask questions when you are unsure of what to do.
- Wait for persons with disabilities to ask for assistance. If they ask, follow their instructions.
- Verbally greet and identify yourself before extending your hand to greet a person who is blind or has low vision. Use the same courtesy when entering or leaving a room or saying goodbye when ending a conversation. Do not just walk away when talking to a person who is blind or has low vision.

DON'T

- Ask questions about a person's impairment unless the person raises it.
- Distract or pet service animals, including guide dogs. They are working.
- Assume that persons with disabilities experience their disability the same way you don't make assumptions about what persons with disabilities can and cannot do.
- Remove a person's cane or guide dog, or lean on someone's wheelchair, or move a person's mobility device. Treat wheelchairs and mobility aids as extensions of the owner's personal space.



If you are interviewing a person who is deaf you may need to recruit a sign interpreter.



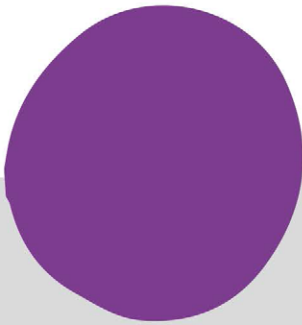
If you are interviewing a person with an intellectual disability, ask in advance what support they would like or require. Does the interviewee want to receive briefing documents in an easy-to-read format, for example, or to be accompanied by a support person of their choice?



To increase the accessibility of information, offer realtime captioning via communication access real-time translation (CART), or provide documents in multiple formats.

Telling the story OF a person and not FOR the person

When communicating with people with disabilities, it is important to talk to them directly instead of relying on a third-party. Unfortunately, there is often a presumption that people with disabilities are not capable of communicating effectively, which can lead to misconceptions and stereotypes.^[xx] For example, when reporting on the success of someone with a disability, journalists may rely on the perspectives of their caregivers instead of speaking directly with the individual. Additionally, using phrases like “despite their disability” can perpetuate negative attitudes towards disability and suggest that it is something that needs to be overcome. Frequently, narratives concerning individuals with disabilities tend to focus on the individuals who do not have disabilities but are present in their lives.



Several news portals tend to use phrases like “despite their disability,” “suffering from their disability,” and “incapability to work like normal people” while reporting on the success of individuals with disabilities in competitive exams such as Civil Services or judicial exams. Such storylines primarily focus on the individuals’ conditions, which fall under medical model of disability. It is highly recommended that such stories should also emphasize the societal structure to demonstrate how other barriers played a role.

Avoiding inspirational sensationalism: Benevolent Ableism

Frequently, there exists a tendency to employ inspiring stories with the aim of increasing readership and viewership of news. In this process, the focus on the individuals’ stories can become muddled, and they can be elevated to an unrealistic level.^[xxi] This portrayal not only alters their outward perception but also highlights their difference from the general public. Such a practice can be deemed unhealthy as it may lead to prejudices towards persons with disabilities, as they are being portrayed as inspirational solely due to their disability.

This attitude can give rise to a similar phenomenon, which is overprotection towards individuals with disabilities. This overprotection often deprives them of opportunities that they would otherwise have had. While the intentions behind overprotection may be genuine care from parents, relatives, spouses, or even the government, the result is that these individuals are prevented from living a dignified life. This overprotectionism is often caused by multiple barriers, including attitudinal barriers that arise from the person’s interaction with society. Fear of the society’s capacity and capabilities is usually the root cause of such barriers.

INTERNATIONAL BEST PRACTISES

European Parliament

The European Parliament released a “Glossary of Sensitive Language for Internal and External Communication”.^[xxii] The purpose of this glossary is to assist the European Parliament staff in communicating accurately on topics related to disability, LGBTQI+ issues, race, ethnicity, and religion. It is recommended that staff directly ask members of diverse groups how they prefer to be addressed. However, if that is not feasible, we kindly request that you refer to the following glossary of appropriate language, created this glossary.

Singapore

Singapore’s Disabled People Association published a “Glossary of Disability Terminology,” a comprehensive booklet on all terminologies and phraseology related to the subject of disability. The compilation serves as an essential guide to words and phrases acceptable to people with disabilities. The compilation also incorporates the symbols in daily usage and signifies how descriptions for such symbols should be written for PwDs.

Australia

People with Disability Australia (PWDA) published a small language guide to provide a broad overlook of the language guide about disability. The guide addresses multiple components like individual-centric language, correct terminologies used while talking with PwD, commonly used phrases and their intended meanings, ^[xxiii]

United States of America

The National Centre on Disability and Journalism has published the “Disability Language Style Guide”. The guide provides a comprehensive background about the most frequently used phrases and words and suggestions around disability and then provides recommendations for proper usage of such language. The guide was developed by the National Center on Disability and Journalism at Arizona State University’s Walter Cronkite School of Journalism and Mass Communication and was last updated in the summer of 2021.^[xxiv]

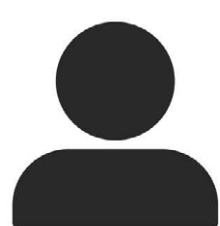
United Kingdom

The government of the United Kingdom has released a guidance document titled “Inclusive language: words to use and avoid when writing about disability”.^[xxv] This guidance provides language guidelines wherein it enumerates suggestions under the head of collective terms and label, usage of positive and not negative language and everyday language usage when referring to PwDs. achievement of PwD through national awards in different categories that underlines their achievement across sectors. Nevertheless, the government’s efforts’ success is contingent upon all stakeholders’ active involvement.

FRAMEWORK FOR DISABILITY INCLUSIVE LANGUAGE

In furtherance of our preceding discussion, in this chapter, we provide a set of guidelines and a detailed list of accepted terms and phrases around disability. It is to be noted that these guidelines and lists is not exhaustive in any form. They are derived from the best practices from various jurisdictions and international principles.[\[xxvi\]](#)

*Broad guidelines while
talking about disability*



Person-Centric Communication

It has been widely understood that we should use people's first language, especially for PwD. People-first language is the most widely accepted form of language, which emphasizes the person first, rather than their disability. This type of language is used in the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities and is considered respectful and dignifying.[\[xxvii\]](#) People-first language involves placing a reference to the person or group before the reference to the disability. For example, instead of saying "disabled children", we can say "children with disabilities". However, there are some exceptions to this rule. For instance, when referring to persons who are blind, we can say either "blind persons" or "persons who are blind", and the same applies to deaf or deafblind persons. It is important to use language that is respectful and sensitive to the person's human dignity.[\[xxviii\]](#)



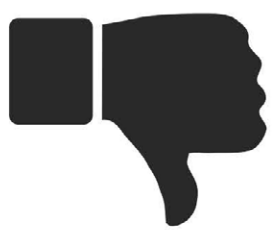
Ask an Individual

When it comes to discussing disability, it's important to be respectful and sensitive to the preferences of PwD. Just like the concept of gender inclusivity, one can ask PwD how they prefer to be referred to. For example, it's as simple as asking "Is it okay if I refer to you as a blind person?". This practice shows inclusivity and respect towards PwD and helps to break down any preconceived ideas or biases surrounding disability in society.[\[xxix\]](#)



Use disability only where it is relevant

In your communication, try to refrain from labeling individuals and avoid mentioning their disability or impairment unless it is necessary. Instead, focus on their skills or requirements and only refer to their impairment when it brings clarity or provides useful information. For instance, if you are discussing quality assessment for Braille documents, you can mention that your colleague is a “Braille user” or can “read Braille” instead of saying that they are blind. It is important to understand that the relevant fact is the person’s skills, not their impairment. Always use positive and empowering language while communicating with individuals.[xxx]



Don’t use disability as a derogatory parallel or to perpetuate stereotype

As discussed previously, the medical model and charity model of disability are two approaches that view disability in a negative light.[xxxi] Under the medical model, disability is seen as a health issue that requires a cure, and individuals with disabilities are not considered as rights holders. On the other hand, the charity model portrays disability as a burden or problem that non-disabled people must resolve, leading to negative attitudes and stereotypes. This approach depicts individuals with disabilities as objects of pity and charity, perpetuating misconceptions that further marginalize them. Disability is a normal occurrence and majority of the population will have one or the other form of disability. Hence, PwD have a normal life and nothing exceptional about it. They become disabled by their interaction with the environment and hence emphasis should be on the society. It is important to avoid portraying persons with disabilities as inspirational or “superhuman” as this implies that it is uncommon for them to lead successful and fulfilling lives. Descriptions such as “courageous” or “brave” or having “overcome” their disability can be patronizing and should be refrained from.[xxxii]



Make usual informal conversation

In everyday conversations, it’s not essential to modify the usual phrases to highlight a person’s disability. For instance, you can suggest taking a walk to a person who uses a wheelchair or asking if they’ve heard the news to someone who is deaf. These are common phrases that can be used without emphasizing a person’s disability.



Avoid patronizing individuals or their disability

Usage of Euphemisms is a common practice in both formal and informal conversation. This perpetuates the idea that disability needs to be either softened, hidden or underplayed. For example, “differently abled” is problematic because, as some advocates note, we are all differently abled.



Disability community is not homogenous

People with disabilities exhibit both inter and intra-variation, resulting in a diverse disability community. It is important to be aware of this diversity while interacting with individuals or organizations. It is also important to acknowledge that there is still a significant population within the disability community that remains underrepresented. For instance, people living with invisible disabilities are still not represented in the mainstream space wherein wheelchair has become a symbolism of disability representation. A very minuscule population within the disability community uses wheelchairs. A person living with Thalassemia has an invisible disability, but one of the most serious conditions wherein they have to undergo multiple blood transfusions within a month for survival. It is imperative to acknowledge this limitation while reporting on the disability.

Table of words and phrases for disability inclusive communication

For General

 What to say	 What not to say	 Observations
- Personal Pronouns - Use accessible parking, parking reserved for persons with disabilities, accessible bathroom.	- Able-bodied, Abnormal, Normal - Disabled/handicapped parking, handicapped bathroom.	Referring to someone who does not have a disability as a “normal person” implies that people with disabilities are strange or odd. Use abnormal only in a medical/scientific setting like “abnormal curvature of bone.” Avoid using the word “abnormal” to describe people.
- Use person with disability	- Differently abled, special, gifted	Terms like “differently-abled”, although well-meaning, can be received as condescending, offensive or simply a way of avoiding talking about disability. Infantilizing connotation. The notion is that despite differences in everyone’s needs, referring to the needs of only disabled people as “special” carries an infantilizing connotation.
Use “someone with a drug/alcohol addiction” op “someone with alcoholism.”	Addict, Alcoholic, Junki	Addiction is a neurobiological disease which “impaired control over drug use, compulsive use, and continued use despite harm and/or craving”.
Use “person with a congenital disability”, “person living with congenital disability.”	Defective, defect	When describing a disability, avoid “defect” or “defective” as they imply the person is sub-par or incomplete.
Use alternative words like Unexpected, ambivalent, and frozen to define the characteristics of a person or situation.	Metaphors such as blind-sided, fall on deaf ears, paralyzed	Using disability identity as a metaphor for ignorance can be harmful for a person with disabilities. Instead of using expressions like “blindsided”, it is important to communicate directly and avoid using disability-related terms as a substitute for negative connotations.

For General

 What to say	 What not to say	 Comment
- Have [disability/impairment/condition]	- suffer from, afflicted by, stricken by, troubled with	Person with disability doesn't suffer as disability is not a harmful add-on that has to be cured. This perpetuates the medical model of disability.
-Use "person with disability"	- Handicap., Handicapped	Handicap can be used both as a verb and as a noun wherein latter denotes
Use "got overly excited" instead of "spazzed out". Say "that was silly of me" instead of "I'm such a spaz" .	Spaz, Spastic	The term "spaz" comes from "spastic", which is a medical term used to refer to spasms, especially spasms related to high muscle tone, which can be a characteristic of someone with cerebral palsy

For Physical Disability

Use person with a physical disability, person with a physical impairment, wheelchair user, person who uses a wheelchair, person with a mobility disability, person with a mobility impairment, person using a mobility device	cpipple, cpip, cpippled, invalid, defopmed, lame, handicapped, physically challenged, pepson with physical limitations, limp	Using "cripple", "deformed" or similar terminologies to refer to a person, or as a metaphor, is offensive. These terms define people by their perceived deficits, ignoring their strengths, capabilities, and potential. This further perpetuates the medical model of disability and not social model.
Use "wheelchair user" or "person who uses a wheelchair."	Wheelchair-bound	People are not bound to their wheelchairs. Wheelchairs transform barriers into possibilities, opening doors to freedom and societal engagement.

For Visual Disability

 What to say	 What not to say	 Comment
Use blind person, person who is blind, person with a vision/visual disability, person with a vision/visual impairment, person with low vision, deaf-blind person	the blind, partially-sighted	Use “blind” for someone who has complete loss of sight. Use “legally blind” for someone who has almost complete loss of sight. Use “limited vision”, “low vision”, “visually impaired” for someone who is neither legally or completely blind. Some people object to “visually impaired” as it characterizes the condition in terms of lacking.

For Speech Disability

Use person who uses a communication device, person who uses an alternative method of communication.	Dumb, non-verbal., can’t talk	Indian Sign Language is a recognised form of language. Hence, ISL is a different mode of communication for people with speech disability. It can’t qualify as impairment as non-disabled people can also be presumed to be impaired for inability to communicate in ISL.
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For Hearing Disability

Use deaf person, person who is deaf, person with a hearing disability, person with a hearing impairment, person with hearing loss, hard-of-hearing person, deafblind person	the deaf, hearing impaired, deaf and dumb, deaf and mute	Same as above
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For Intellectual Disability

Use person with an intellectual disability. Person with learning disability, Persons with psycho-social disabilities	retarded, simple, slow, afflicted, braindamaged, intellectually challenged, subnormal, of unsound mind, feeble-minded, mentally handicapped	“Person with an intellectual disability” prioritizes the individual first. It recognizes the inherent dignity and humanity of every person, regardless of any disability. Terms like “dumb” and “retarded” dehumanize and demean, perpetuating harmful stereotypes and fueling discrimination.
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For Psycho-social Disability

 What to say	 What not to say	 Comment
Use person with a psychosocial disability	insane, crazy, maniac, psycho, hypersensitive, lunatic, demented, panicked, agitated, mentally deranged, mentally ill.	Replacing outdated9 inaccurate terms with the preferred terminology reflects the lived experiences of individuals with pyscho-social disabilities. These terms often carry historical baggage associated with negative portrayals and limited understanding

For Other Disability

Person affected by leprosy	leper, leprosy patient	See above sections
person with albinism	albino	See above sections
person with Down syndrome person with trisomy-21	mongoloid, special person, Down	See above sections
Use “dwarf”, “someone with dwarfism/short stature” or “little” person.	midget, dwarf, stunted	“Midget” comes from a time when Little People were a source of entertainment. “Dwarf” is a medically acceptable term. “Little Person” is socially acceptable.
Use Person with Cross Disability	deaf and dumb Multiple impairments	instead of ‘deaf and dumb’ which is offensive, ‘cross-disability’ unites ALL disabilities: acquired, congenital intellectual, sensory, mobility, etc. It celebrates diversity within the disability community, promoting inclusion and understanding

RECOMMENDATIONS AND CONCLUSION

The transformation of societal attitudes towards inclusivity is a protracted and systematic process that necessitates unwavering support at all levels of governance. Yet, concurrently, an onus rests upon each individual to actively pursue knowledge and understanding of their neighbors' needs. Accordingly, alongside the crucial role played by governmental structures, it is paramount for all facets of society to actively contribute to the construction of an inclusive environment. This commitment can manifest through seemingly small but impactful actions, such as the preservation of accessible infrastructure meticulously crafted by public authorities and the conscious avoidance of erecting physical barriers in public spaces. These seemingly minute shifts collectively represent a significant trajectory toward the realization of a barrier-free society.

The following overarching recommendations, therefore, provide a framework for implementation by diverse stakeholders:

1. Development of disability-sensitive language framework: All enterprises, encompassing both public and private sectors, are encouraged to cultivate an institutionally ingrained environment of disability-sensitive communication. This objective can be attained through the implementation of various initiatives, such as:

- Development of a comprehensive guide tailored to their specific field with guidelines for appropriate disability terminology and phrasing.
- Regular sensitisation workshops or upskilling programs designed to raise awareness and understanding of disability issues within the workforce.
- Integration of disability-related modules into existing training programs to ensure consistent and effective communication practices.

3. Accurate and solution-oriented storytelling: Narratives centered on individuals with disabilities should strive for balanced and affirmative portrayals, aligning with the constitutional commitment to amplifying the agency of marginalized groups like women, children, and indigenous peoples.

Such narratives should depict individuals with disabilities in active roles, eschewing passive representations.

- Always focus on the individual and the purpose of the story. Highlight the human emotions that resonate with the audience, regardless of physical abilities or assistive devices. The individual's disability should not be the central focus of the narrative.
- Avoid portraying characters solely through their impairments or reliance on assistive devices. These elements should be incidental to the character's essence and the story's emotional core. Treat them as natural extensions of the individual, rather than defining characteristics.



Does the text use person-first language (except as requested by a person with disability)?



Is it free of pejorative language, euphemisms, and ableist language?



*Is the language simple and concise?
Does it avoid jargon and idioms?*



Did you consider using various accessible formats (sign language interpretation, Braille, large print, easy-to-read, etc.)?



Does the translation describe persons with disabilities accurately?

Conclusion

In 2011, the World Health Organisation developed a world report on disability for the first time. Its introduction showed how disabled persons aren't "other people", but that all of us at some point will be "temporarily or permanently impaired" and those "who survive to old age will experience increasing difficulties in functioning." [xxxiii]

Hence, we have to shift our understanding to this reality that disability is a norm and not exception. Purple Fest is a noble initiative aimed at providing a unified voice to the disability movement. Its various recreational activities and conferences create a parallel world where individuals are not hindered by any barriers that make them feel disabled. Over the years, the disability movement in India has made significant progress in advancing towards a more inclusive society.

Purple Fest marks the beginning of our journey towards creating an inclusive world. It is imperative that we address the fundamental issues of attitudinal barriers and communication to achieve our goal. We hope that our efforts at Purple Fest, along with this document, will serve as guiding principles for promoting inclusivity and breaking down barriers.

The unwavering support of the central government and their commitment to the welfare of this community further reinforces our belief in "Sabha Saath. Sabka Vikas, Sabha Vishwas. Sabka Prayas". As our Hon'ble said while launching the Accessible India Campaign that, "Sabka-Sath, Sabka Vikas' would be successful in real terms when development reaches every section of society". Let us work towards realising this dream.

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